Fixing Accessibility in Video Game Menus

Project Members: Mason Adair, Jorge Canales, Lukas Jaspe, Aidan Moore, Yannick Morsen, Jack Zhang

Pain-point:

Video games have had a long history with accessibility and are frequently used as examples of positive accommodation to audiences. However, despite the effort many recent games have made in regards to accessibility, there are still blind spots in the integration of such options. This comes in the form of inconsistent placement of options, a lack of accommodation for certain issues, and overall UI/UX choices that make navigating menus as a whole very difficult. Our objective is to make a framework for video game settings that have dedicated accessibility options. The goal is to avoid the frustrating search many gamers endure to find their needs met only to find them poorly placed or quite simply not there at all.

Target Group:

Our major demographic we're focused on will be gamers who need accommodations for any mental or physical impairments. A disability should not preclude you from enjoying video games. Someone who has seizures due to flashing lights shouldn't be stopped from playing video games because of graphical effects. There should be an option for them to turn them off, rather than just getting a warning when they open up the game. People with arachnophobia can enjoy a game if the developers allow an option to change the model of spiders to anything else. ALL of them should be able to easily find these options by clicking on the accessibility submenu.

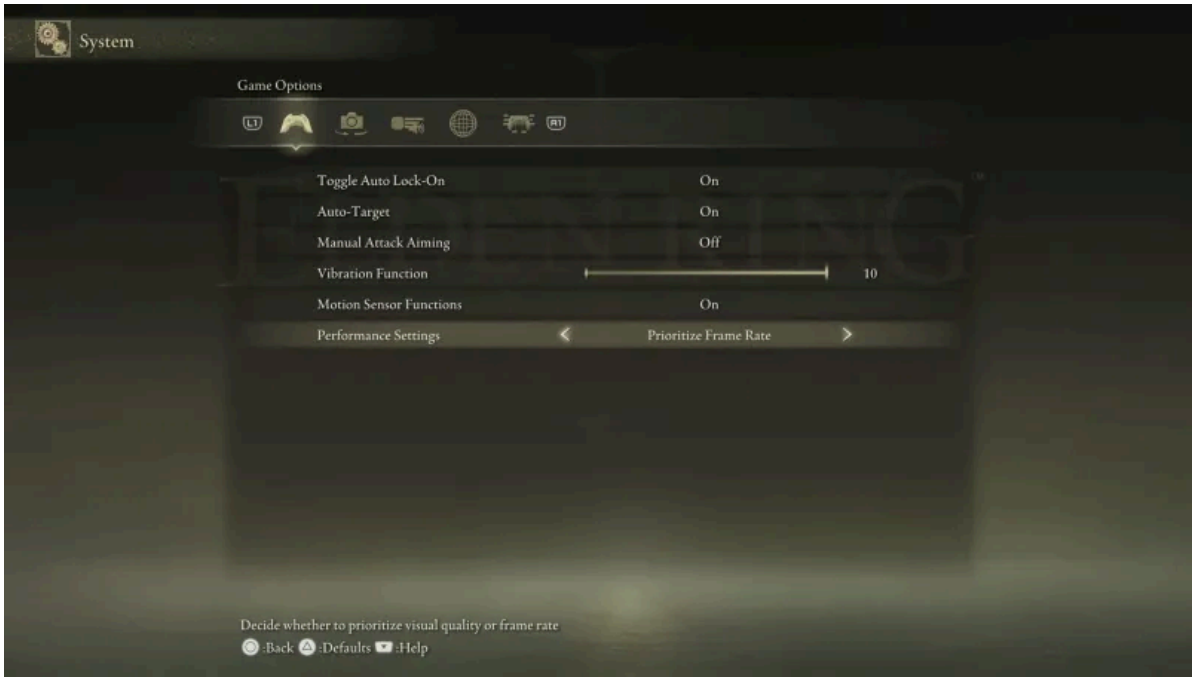
Proposed Solution:

The proposed solution to this problem is a functional framework that aims to be an ideal accessibility menu. Whether updated for a product that has already been released or for a project still in production, this submenu aims to provide quality of life improvements and options for a variety of impairments and be a simple shortcut to common options that are often thrown into unrelated menus.

Feasibility and Scope:

The scope will be limited to providing a configuration menu framework that aims to demonstrate various options for accessibility, most notably in the form of an interactive demo. In this demo, the user will go through the options presented and see the effects of those options (i.e. choosing a specific type of colorblind option will change the screen colors to be of that colorblindness) allowing them to see the results without having to switch to gameplay to see the effects of their options.

Examples of Poor Accessibility:



Pictured here is Elden Ring's menu. A noticeable problem with the menu's design is that there are few accessibility options to speak of, let alone its own tab. The most that can be considered are subtitle options, controller/keyboard remapping, and camera sensitivity. I know that the Souls-like genre is notoriously difficult, but why make it harder for people who are impaired to enjoy?

Pictured here is the options menu for debut indie game Unbeatable, first image depicts hovering over the Resolution option while the second depicts when you select the option. Although there are plenty of accessibility and graphical options, there is a major lack of organization in the menus. The main issues are the inability to differentiate a header for an option from its current setting, the lack of color contrast from when you hover over an option and select it, lack of direction when trying to change the option, and inconsistent formatting as some text on the side is white. This is an example of a menu that needs categories for its options.

Group Contributions:

Jorge Canales: Wrote out the proposal and included Elden Ring screenshot of UI, providing alt text under the picture.

Lukas Jaspe: Helped in cleaning up the rough draft of the proposal and provided the other screenshot of bad UI design in relation to accessibility along with explaining it.

Mason Adair: Gave examples of the issue we're trying to solve, which helped in realizing our proposal was realistic and an actual issue not solely contained to a very niche audience.

Jack Zhang: Helped brainstorm ideas and gave examples of the issue talked about in the proposal.

Yannick Morsen: Provided some insight into the issue, giving his own experience on the problem.

Aidan Moore: Provided feedback on the proposal and helped find people who were willing to talk about their own experience with accessibility in video games.